The Ugly Duckling

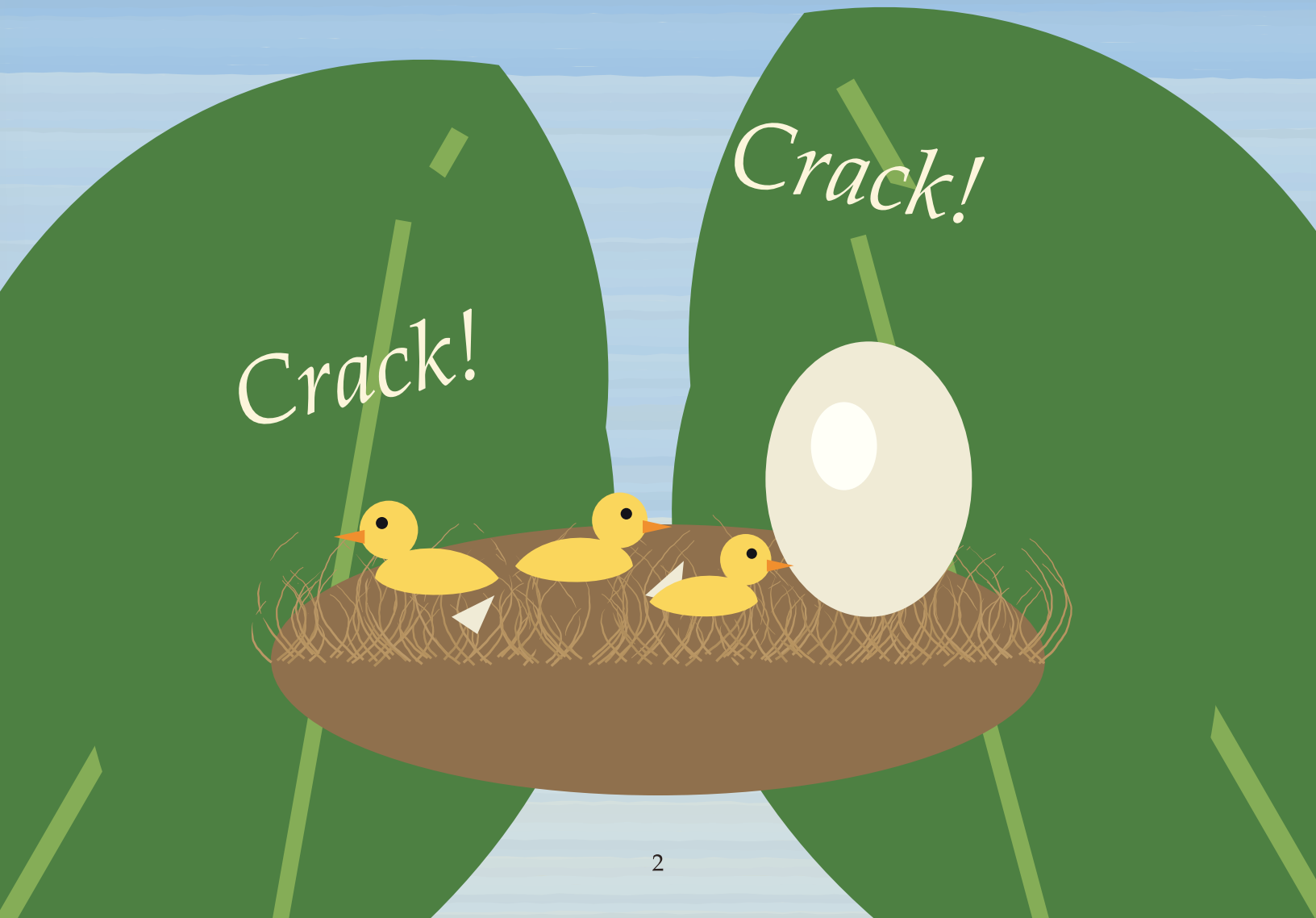
after Hans Christian Andersen



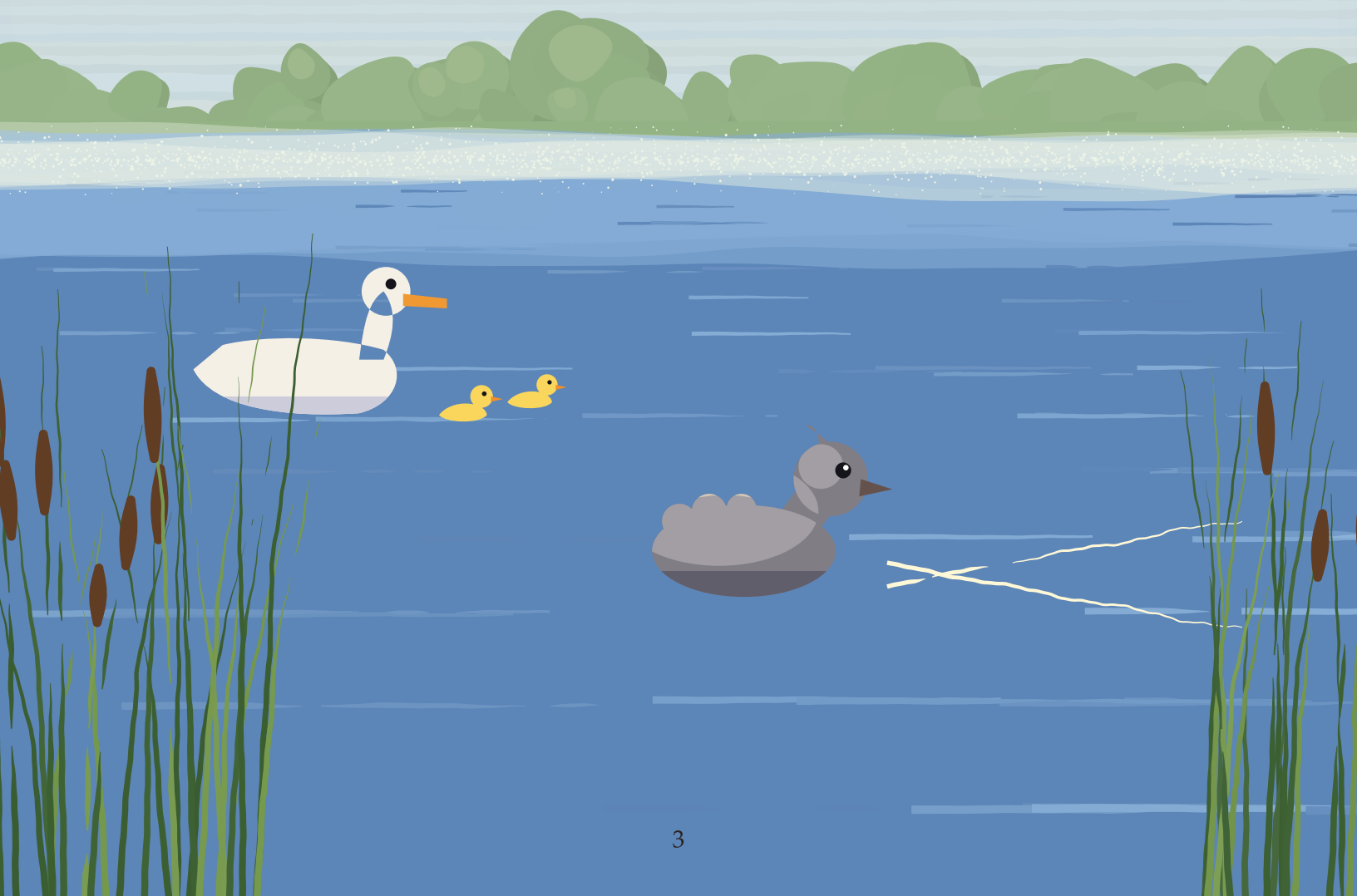
It was summer in the country. Down by the old farm, a mother duck sat on her nest.



One by one, out came the ducklings, small and yellow. “Peep! Peep!” But the biggest egg did not crack.



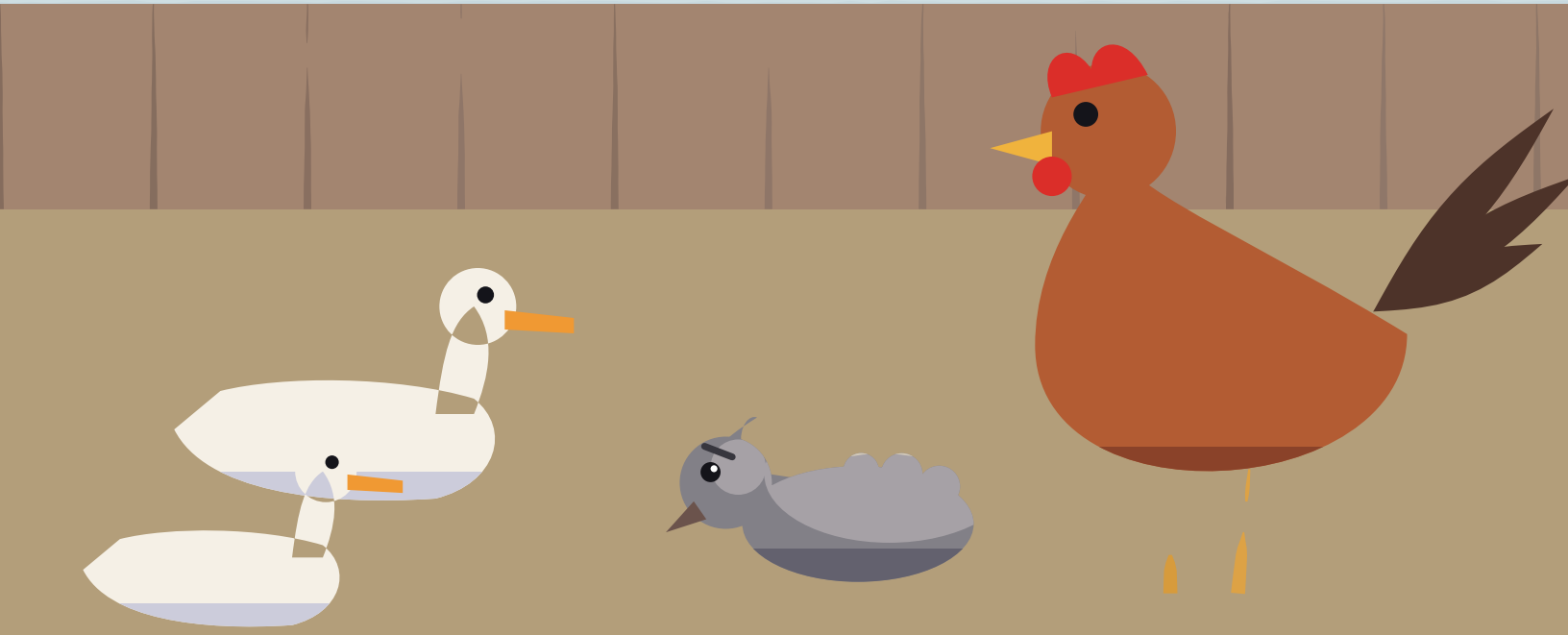
At last it did. Out tumbled a duckling who was big, and grey, and not like the others at all. “Never mind,” said his mother. “Look how well he swims.”



But in the duck yard, the ducks pecked him and the hens chased him.

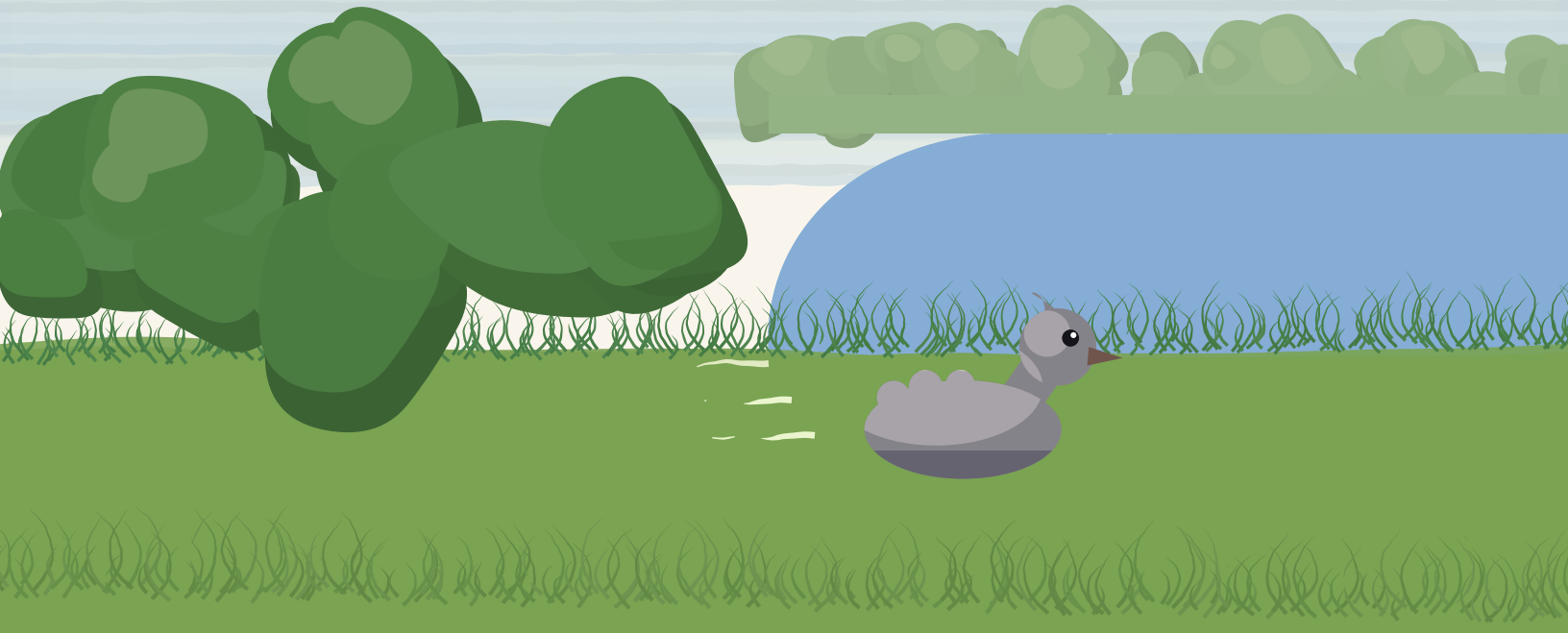
“How big and ugly he is!”

they said.



His mother hushed them, but they would not stop.

So one morning the grey duckling ran away,
under the hedge and out into the wide marsh.



The wild ducks looked at him. “You are very ugly,” they said. “But you may stay, if you keep out of the way.” So he hid in the reeds,



all alone.



In the crooked little cottage lived a hen and a cat.

"Can you lay eggs?"
asked the hen.

"No."

"Can you purr?"
asked the cat.

"No."

"Then you are no use at all!"



“But I love to swim,” said the duckling, “and to dive to the bottom of the water.” “What nonsense!” said the hen. So the duckling went back out into the wide world.





Autumn came. Great white birds flew over the marsh, calling to each other.

The duckling did not know their name. But he stretched his neck after them, and he loved them,



more than he had ever loved anything.

Then winter came, cold and hard. The pond began to freeze. All night the duckling swam



to keep his little circle of water open. His mother had always said he swam well.



Spring came. The duckling spread his wings, and up he flew.

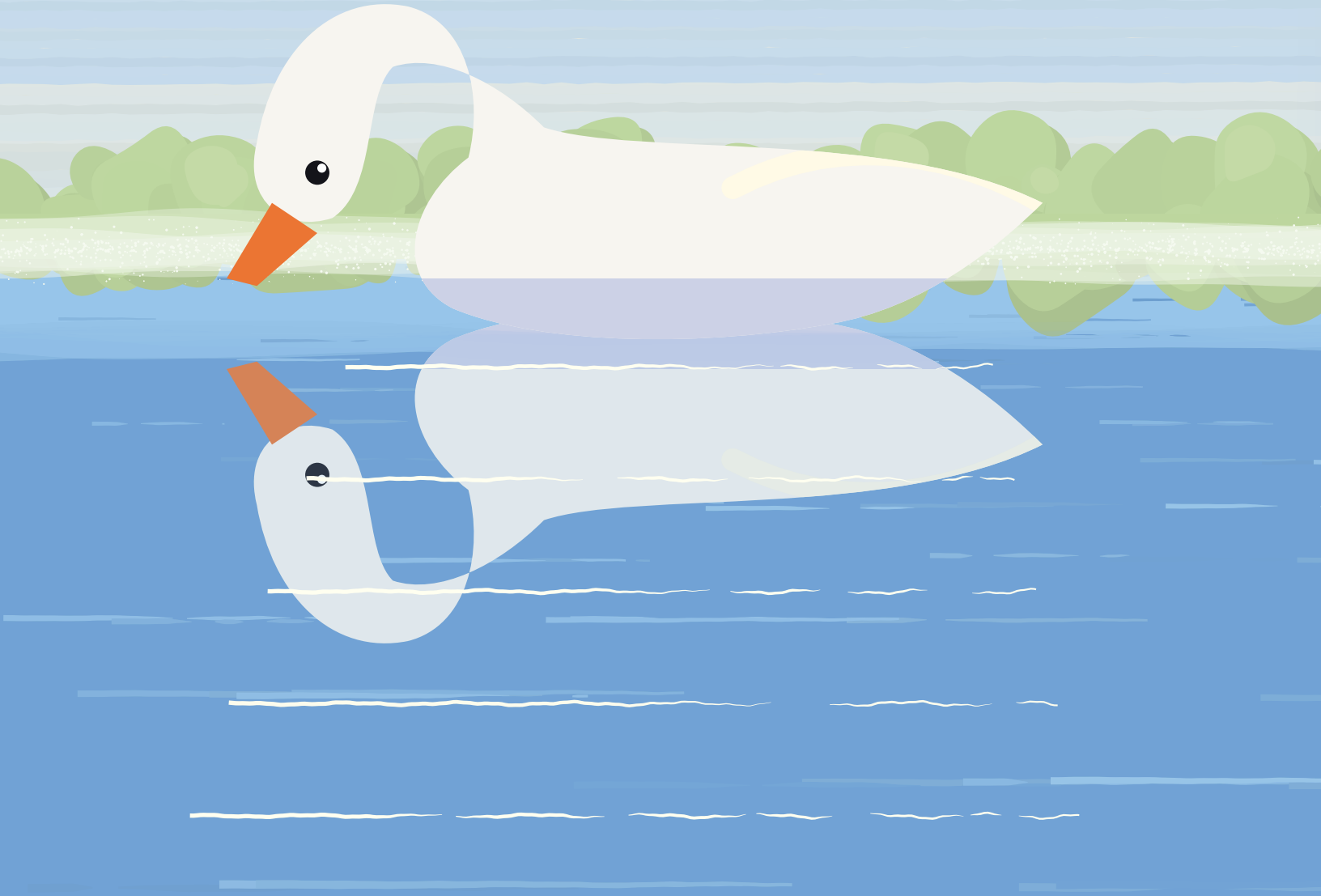


There on the water were three white swans. “They will chase me away,” he thought. But the swans swam to meet him, and they bowed their heads.



The duckling bowed his head too.

And there in the water was a swan.

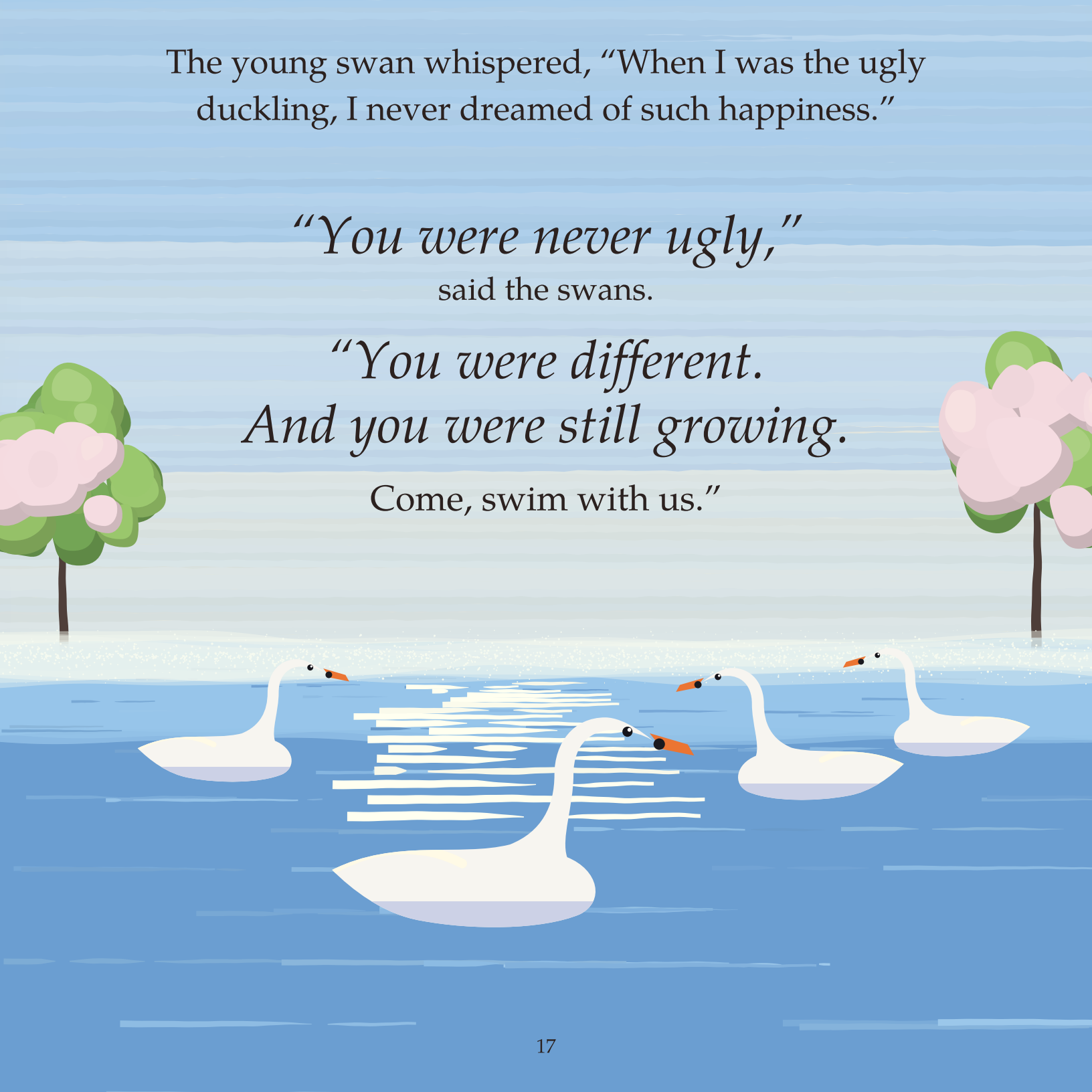


The young swan whispered, "When I was the ugly duckling, I never dreamed of such happiness."

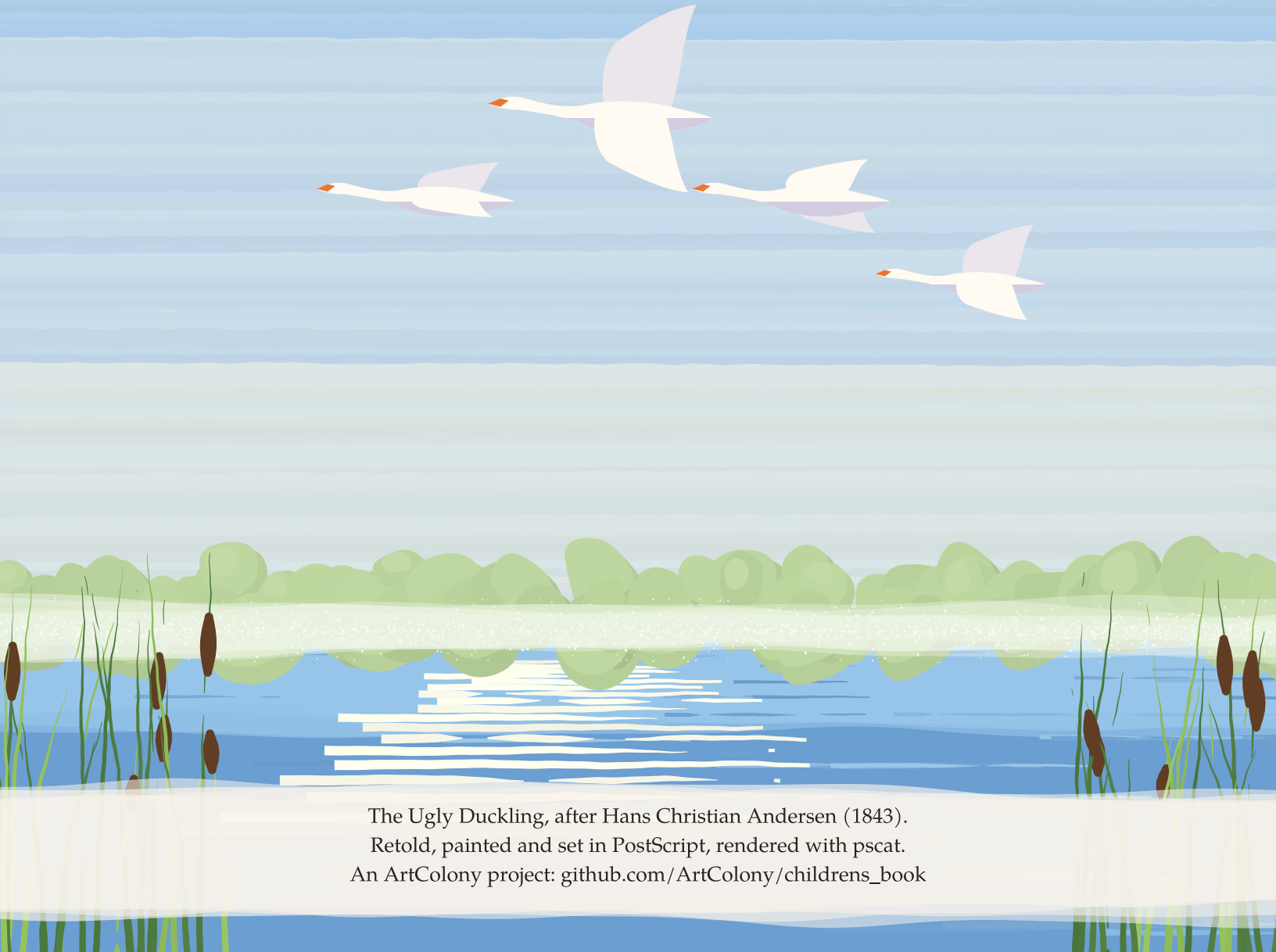
"You were never ugly,"
said the swans.

"You were different.
And you were still growing.

Come, swim with us."



The End



The Ugly Duckling, after Hans Christian Andersen (1843).
Retold, painted and set in PostScript, rendered with pscat.
An ArtColony project: github.com/ArtColony/childrens_book